

were touted as better than the metal-clad phones from Apple. It was all the rage until Samsung themselves flipped the switch and started selling metal phones.

In the world of earphones, small electronic devices dangling from their lives from your ears, durability can be the one element that decides whether your purchase serves you for the years to come or disappears abruptly from your life. Cheaply-built earphones come with hissing noises, crackle when adjusted and take just a few hits before crumbling.

Top picks

Let us take a look at the top picks of earphones for different categories.

Popular and inexpensive standard earphones: Philips SHE1360/97. Is all you care about music playing through a little speaker in your ear? Want no gimmicks or promises of revolutionary technology? Philips SHE1360/97 is the earphone you want! Retailing for about ₹ 109 - ₹ 150 based on where you look at, it has a 15-millimetre driver, 16-ohm impedance and a frequency response of 16Hz - 20,000Hz.

Popular and inexpensive in-ear earphones: Sennheiser CX 180 Street II. These offer better noise isolation than Philips earphones mentioned above, while featuring a similar impedance and frequency response. It comes with a set of differently-sized earbuds to help deliver a better fit for your ear. Sennheiser brand, ₹ 889 price tag at Amazon as well as a 4.5-star average rating on Amazon makes this one a value-for-money best seller.

Wireless and revolutionary earphones: Dot STEREO featuring aptX. These are extremely small earphones that you can keep in your ears without wires dangling out. While there have been Bluetooth earphones available previously, those had wires connected to the second earphone in the pair. Dot comes with aptX technology that minimises latency and audio-syncing issues while wirelessly delivering the full audio bandwidth

for better quality music. Weighing just 3.5 grams, this lightweight pair comes with a heavyweight price tag of above ₹ 10,000 unless you get it from Indiegogo.com for a discount.

High-end noise-cancellation earphones: Bose QuietComfort 20 Acoustic Noise Cancelling. Bose's legendary active noise-cancelling technology remains unparalleled in their full-size headphones as well as these earphones. The design looks like a hybrid of a standard earphone and an in-ear phone, but that is due to the need to house the electronics needed to deliver noise cancellation to the user.

An inbuilt microphone senses external noise and an equal and opposite signal is created, which is converted to sound by the speaker. This essentially cancels the intruding noise and you enjoy almost perfect silence. It is similar to the technology used in aviation headsets worn by pilots.

These earphones also let you activate a setting in which the ambient noise around you is let in so that you can stay aware of your surroundings, if needed. This pair retails at a smart ₹ 25,000, although you might be able to find deals online taking it down by about 20 per cent.

Professional-grade earphones: Inear Stagedriver 4 (SD-4). Used by musicians and artists, this is a flagship offering from German company Inear. It features four balance armature drivers on each channel, black twisted cable and silicon tips. Most audiophile review websites claim that this pair of earphones is one of the best-tuned ones they could find. These cost ₹ 154,000 on Amazon India, but is cheaper abroad at around the equivalent of ₹ 60,000.

What will it be

So have you decided whether to go for another value-for-money earphone or has this article excited you to check out one of the more expensive models? Whichever you select, hope you have a wonderful listening experience! **RFY**

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